

ONOMATOPOEIA

Words that sound like the noise they describe



1 What is it?

Onomatopoeia (on-oh-mat-oh-PEE-uh)

Onomatopoeia is when a word's **sound imitates** the actual sound it's describing — you can practically hear it as you read.

word = the sound itself

2 See it in action

A collision

The plates hit the floor with a crash and a clatter.

An animal

The bees buzzed lazily around the garden.

Something fizzy

The soda can opened with a hiss and a fizz.

In comics

POW! BANG! WHOOSH! — comic books are full of onomatopoeia.



Mfalme says...

The test is simple: **say the word out loud**. If it genuinely sounds like the noise it's describing, it's onomatopoeia.

FUN FACT

Onomatopoeia words are famously different across languages — a dog says "woof" in English, but "wan wan" in Japanese and "hav hav" in Turkish. Even sounds get "translated" differently!

3 Why writers use it

Onomatopoeia helps writers: bring writing to life by adding real, vivid sound — it drops the reader directly into a scene rather than just describing it from a distance.

It's one of the most "physical" techniques — instead of telling the reader something was loud, the word itself performs the loudness.

4 Where you'll spot it

Comic books

BOOM, POW, and CRASH splashed across the panel art in bold letters.

Advertising jingles

Brand names and slogans built entirely around a satisfying sound, like "Snap, Crackle, Pop!"



Watch out!

Not every sound-related word is onomatopoeia! "Loud" and "noisy" describe sound but don't imitate it. Ask: does saying the word out loud actually sound like the noise? If yes, it's onomatopoeia.



Look here!

Onomatopoeia often works best when combined with other techniques — pair it with alliteration ("bang, boom, bash") for maximum impact.

5 Quick recap

Word imitates a sound

You can practically hear it

Brings a scene to life



You got this!

Next time you write an action scene, swap a boring verb for an onomatopoeic one — "the door shut" becomes "the door **slammed**."